



Pairing up

Mating is a crucial moment in animals' lives, because it is the start of the next generation. But before two animals pair up, they need to get over their natural wariness of each other. Animals do this by carrying out courtship rituals, which bond them together like players on a team. Once the bond has been formed, the partners can breed. In most water animals, the male fertilizes the female's eggs once they have been laid. In land animals, the male usually

mates with the female, so that his sperm fertilizes her eggs inside her body.

She then lays the eggs or gives birth to live young.

Dicing with death

A male golden orb web spider approaches a female, which is many times his own size, very cautiously. He announces his arrival by tugging on the web using signals that work like a code. If all goes well, this stops her from treating him as a meal. If she attacks, he nimbly jumps off the web using a silk line to lower himself to safety.

Male grips female with set of claspers at end of abdomen

Internal mating

When butterflies mate, they face in opposite directions with their abdomens locked together. These two blue butterflies may stay like this for more than an hour while the male (on the left) transfers his sperm. Inside the female, the sperm is held in a special storage pouch until her eggs are ready to be fertilized.